CREATURES OF

DEERFIELD, IL



ESSENTIAL HANDBOOK

24 LOCAL CREATURES + EQUIPMENT + PLACES

AMERICAN TOAD

Native toad

#001

TYPE: AMPHIBIAN

An American toad vanishes into moist soil or shrubbery by day, then prowls lawns, gardens, woods, and fields after dark. In spring, a female lays thousands of eggs in long, tangled strings along shallow pond or ditch bottoms.

HOW TO SAY IT: uh-MAIR-ih-kun TOHD

IMPERIAL ADULT LENGTH: 2–3½ in

METRIC ADULT LENGTH: about 5–9 cm

ABILITIES: Spring Trill, Night Hunt

WEAKNESSES: Dry conditions, Breeding-pond loss





TADPOLE TOADLET ADULT

#002

BELTED KINGFISHER

Fish-catching bird



TYPE: BIRD

From a waterside perch, a belted kingfisher spots a fish or crayfish, then plunges bill-first to snatch it. A pair digs a long nesting tunnel into a soft bank, ending in a bare chamber above floodwater.

HOW TO SAY IT: BEL-tid KING-fish-er

IMPERIAL LENGTH: 11–14 in

METRIC LENGTH: 28–35 cm

ABILITIES: Plunge Dive, Bank Burrow

WEAKNESSES: Cloudy water, Bank loss



NESTLING JUVENILE ADULT

BIG DIPPER FIREFLY

Flashing beetle

#003

TYPE: INSECT

At dusk, male big dipper fireflies fly low over yards and fields, flashing a long J-shaped signal for females below. Their glowing larvae spend far longer in moist soil and leaf litter, hunting slugs, snails, and worms.

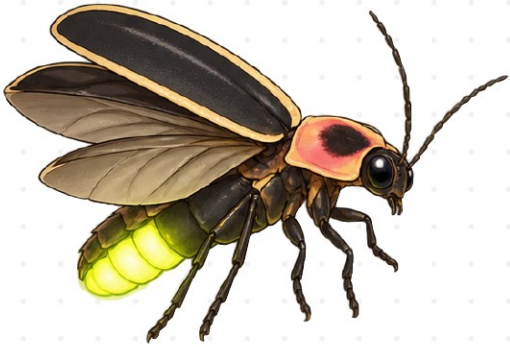
HOW TO SAY IT: BIG DIP-er FIRE-fly

IMPERIAL ADULT BODY LENGTH: about ⅜–½ in

METRIC ADULT BODY LENGTH: 10–14 mm

ABILITIES: J-Flash, Larval Hunt

WEAKNESSES: Light pollution, Pesticides





LARVA PUPA ADULT

#004 BOLD JUMPING SPIDER

Daylight hunter



TYPE: SPIDER

A bold jumper tracks prey with its large forward-facing eyes, stalks close, then springs onto insects or other spiders. A silk safety line trails each leap, catching the spider if its daring pounce falls short.

HOW TO SAY IT: BOHLD JUMP-ing SPY-der

IMPERIAL BODY LENGTH, MALES AND FEMALES: about ¼–¾ in

METRIC BODY LENGTH, MALES AND FEMALES: 6–19 mm

ABILITIES: Precision Pounce, Silk Lifeline

WEAKNESSES: Low light, Freezing weather



HATCHLING JUVENILE ADULT

BUR OAK

Native oak tree

#005

TYPE: TREE

Bur oak casts a broad crown above deeply furrowed bark and bold, rounded-lobed leaves. Its huge acorns wear shaggy-fringed caps, feeding birds and small mammals; established trees can also ride out drought.

HOW TO SAY IT: BUR OHK

IMPERIAL MATURE HEIGHT: 70–80 ft

METRIC MATURE HEIGHT: about 21–24 m

ABILITIES: Drought Endurance, Acorn Supply

WEAKNESSES: Oak wilt, Bur oak blight





ACORN SEEDLING MATURE TREE

#006

COMMON EASTERN BUMBLE BEE

Native pollinator



TYPE: INSECT

A common eastern bumble bee gathers nectar and pollen, carrying both back to its underground nest and moving pollen between blossoms. Its colony lasts one season; only newly mated queens survive winter to start nests the next spring.

HOW TO SAY IT: KOM-un EE-stern BUM-bul BEE

IMPERIAL WORKER BODY LENGTH: about ⅜–9/16 in

METRIC WORKER BODY LENGTH: 9–14 mm

ABILITIES: Pollen Carry, Nectar Harvest

WEAKNESSES: Flower scarcity, Nest loss



LARVA PUPA ADULT

COMMON GREEN DARNER

Migrating dragonfly

#007

TYPE: INSECT

Adult common green darners catch insects on the wing, while their nymphs hunt insects and other small animals underwater. Some darners migrate south in autumn; others stay resident, passing winter as nymphs before emerging in spring.

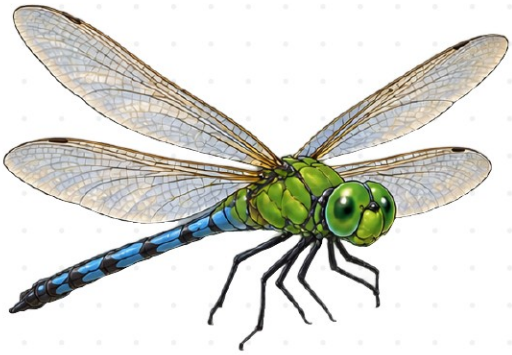
HOW TO SAY IT: KOM-un GREEN DAR-ner

IMPERIAL ADULT LENGTH: 2½–3 in

METRIC ADULT LENGTH: about 6–8 cm

ABILITIES: Air Intercept, Aquatic Hunt

WEAKNESSES: Dry ponds





NYMPH FINAL NYMPH ADULT

#008

COMMON SNAPPING TURTLE

Freshwater turtle



TYPE: REPTILE

A common snapping turtle waits on a pond bottom, then shoots its long neck toward prey within reach. Females leave the water to bury spherical eggs in soil, which hatch in September and October.

HOW TO SAY IT: KOM-un SNAP-ing TUR-tul

IMPERIAL ADULT LENGTH: 8–12 in

METRIC ADULT LENGTH: about 20–30 cm

ABILITIES: Bottom Ambush, Long-Neck Lunge

WEAKNESSES: Exposed nesting trips



EGG HATCHLING ADULT

DOWNY WOODPECKER

Bark-foraging bird

#009

TYPE: BIRD

Downy Woodpeckers scuttle along trunks and slender branches, bracing with stiff tails as they pluck beetle grubs and other insects from bark and plant galls. Pairs carve a nursery cavity in dead wood, then incubate their white eggs inside.

HOW TO SAY IT: DOW-nee WOOD-pek-er

IMPERIAL LENGTH: 5½–6¾ in

METRIC LENGTH: 14–17 cm

ABILITIES: Tail Brace, Wood Excavation

WEAKNESSES: Deadwood loss





NESTLING JUVENILE ADULT

#010 EASTERN CHIPMUNK

Burrow-dwelling mammal



TYPE: MAMMAL

An eastern chipmunk stuffs seeds, nuts, berries, and insects into roomy cheek pouches for the dash to its tunnel system. It stores food below ground and becomes inactive in winter, waking between rests rather than fully hibernating.

HOW TO SAY IT: EE-stern CHIP-munk

IMPERIAL BODY LENGTH: 5–6 in

METRIC BODY LENGTH: about 13–15 cm

ABILITIES: Cheek Pouches, Tunnel Escape

WEAKNESSES: Burrow loss, Food scarcity



NEWBORN YOUNG ADULT

EASTERN TIGER SALAMANDER

Burrowing salamander

#011

TYPE: AMPHIBIAN

Eastern tiger salamanders spend much of the year underground, then surface at night and migrate to ponds to breed. Gilled larvae grow in fish-free water, leave it in late summer or autumn, and become dark, spotty juveniles.

HOW TO SAY IT: EE-stern TYE-ger SAL-uh-man-der

IMPERIAL AVERAGE ADULT LENGTH: 7–8¼ in

METRIC AVERAGE ADULT LENGTH: about 18–21 cm

ABILITIES: Burrow Hideout, Night Hunt

WEAKNESSES: Fish-filled ponds, Urban disturbance





LARVA JUVENILE ADULT

#012 GIANT PUFFBALL

Spore-producing fungus



TYPE: FUNGUS

The giant puffball's vast round fruiting body rises above hidden mycelium in grassy places. As it ripens, pale skin flakes away and reveals a yellow-green to brown spore mass, released when conditions are warm and moist.

HOW TO SAY IT: JYE-unt PUF-bawl

IMPERIAL FRUITING BODY WIDTH: nearly 20 in

METRIC FRUITING BODY WIDTH: about 51 cm

ABILITIES: Spore Release, Hidden Mycelium

WEAKNESSES: Dry weather, Short fruiting season



MYCELIUM YOUNG MATURE

JACK-IN-THE-PULPIT

Woodland spring wildflower

#013

TYPE: WILDFLOWER

Each spring, Jack-in-the-pulpit pushes from an underground corm, lifting three-part leaves beside its striped green-and-purple hood. The club-shaped spadix stands inside the spathe; later, a female plant can finish the season with a vivid spike of red berries.

HOW TO SAY IT: JAK-in-thuh-PUL-pit

IMPERIAL MATURE HEIGHT: 1–3 ft

METRIC MATURE HEIGHT: 0.3–0.9 m

ABILITIES: Spring Return, Berry Cluster

WEAKNESSES: Drought





SHOOT FLOWER FRUIT

#014 JACK-O'-LANTERN MUSHROOM

Glowing wood decomposer



TYPE: FUNGUS

Jack-o'-lantern mushrooms blaze orange in clusters from stumps and buried hardwood roots, while most of the fungus stays hidden as mycelium in the wood. Their gills can glow green in darkness, and this fungus is toxic if eaten.

HOW TO SAY IT: JAK-oh-LAN-tern MUSH-room

IMPERIAL CAP WIDTH: 2–6 in

METRIC CAP WIDTH: 5–15 cm

ABILITIES: Green Glow, Wood Breakdown

WEAKNESSES: Hardwood dependence



MYCELIUM BUTTONS MATURE

MONARCH BUTTERFLY

Milkweed-dependent migrant

#015

TYPE: BUTTERFLY

A monarch's orange wings carry black veins and white-spotted borders, while its caterpillar wears bold black, yellow, and ivory bands. Adults sip flower nectar; eastern migrants travel to Mexico, and caterpillars develop only on milkweed.

HOW TO SAY IT: MON-ark BUT-er-fly

IMPERIAL ADULT WINGSPAN: 3–4 in

METRIC ADULT WINGSPAN: 7–10 cm

ABILITIES: Milkweed Defense, Long Migration

WEAKNESSES: Milkweed loss, Larval predation





CATERPILLAR CHRYSALIS BUTTERFLY

#016 PERIODICAL CICADA (BROOD XIII)

Synchronized 17-year brood



TYPE: INSECT

Brood XIII's nymphs spend 17 years underground sipping root sap, then three Lake County Magicicada species surface together in a synchronized rush. Adults sing in treetops for several weeks, mate, and lay eggs in branch tips.

HOW TO SAY IT: peer-ee-OD-ih-kul sih-KAY-duh

IMPERIAL ADULT BODY LENGTH: about 1.5 in

METRIC ADULT BODY LENGTH: about 3.8 cm

ABILITIES: Root-Sap Feed, Mass Emergence

WEAKNESSES: Predators, Poor flight



NYMPH FRESH ADULT ADULT

PILLBUG

Land-dwelling isopod

#017

TYPE: CRUSTACEAN

Pillbugs hide under damp leaves, stones, and logs, where they feed on decaying plant matter as land-dwelling isopod crustaceans. Unlike similar-looking sowbugs, pill-rolling isopods curl into a tight ball when disturbed.

HOW TO SAY IT: PIL-bug

IMPERIAL ADULT LENGTH (COMMON PILLBUG EXAMPLE): about 1/3–3/4 in

METRIC ADULT LENGTH (COMMON PILLBUG EXAMPLE): about 8.5–18 mm

ABILITIES: Ball Armor, Leaf Recycling

WEAKNESSES: Dry air





YOUNG JUVENILE ADULT

#018 QUAKING ASPEN

Fluttering northern tree



TYPE: TREE

A breeze can set quaking aspen's round leaves trembling on their flattened stalks. This pale-barked northern Illinois tree spreads through lateral-root suckers, so one grove can become a broad family of genetically connected stems.

HOW TO SAY IT: KWAY-king AS-pen

IMPERIAL MATURE HEIGHT: 40–70 ft

METRIC MATURE HEIGHT: 12–21 m

ABILITIES: Root Cloning, Quaking Leaves

WEAKNESSES: Deep shade



ROOT SUCKER SAPLING MATURE

SHAGBARK HICKORY

Shaggy-barked nut tree

#019

TYPE: TREE

A slow-growing native to the Chicago Region, shagbark hickory wears its name in long gray plates that curl away from the trunk. Its five-to-seven-leaflet leaves rise above thick-husked fall nuts that feed wildlife.

HOW TO SAY IT: SHAG-bark HIK-uh-ree

IMPERIAL MATURE HEIGHT: 60–80 ft

METRIC MATURE HEIGHT: 18–24 m

ABILITIES: Bark Plates, Nut Supply

WEAKNESSES: Slow growth, Transplant stress





NUT SAPLING MATURE

#020 SOUTHERN FLYING SQUIRREL

Nocturnal tree glider



TYPE: MAMMAL

At night, a southern flying squirrel stretches its wrist-to-ankle membrane and glides between Lake County trees, steering with its broad tail. It nests in grass-lined tree cavities and may share them with other flying squirrels.

HOW TO SAY IT: SUH-thern FLY-ing SKWUR-ul

IMPERIAL HEAD-TO-TAIL LENGTH: about 8.6–9.8 in

METRIC HEAD-TO-TAIL LENGTH: about 22–25 cm

ABILITIES: Membrane Glide, Tail Rudder

WEAKNESSES: Canopy gaps, Cavity loss



NEWBORN YOUNG ADULT

SPOTTED TOUCH-ME-NOT

Explosive seed-pod wildflower

#021

TYPE: WILDFLOWER

Spotted touch-me-not hangs orange, dark-spotted flowers from a juicy green stem in Illinois' wet shade. As a ripe seedpod is touched, it snaps open and flings seeds; bees and hummingbirds visit the flowers.

HOW TO SAY IT: SPOT-id TUCH-mee-NOT

IMPERIAL PLANT HEIGHT: 2–5 ft

METRIC PLANT HEIGHT: 0.6–1.5 m

ABILITIES: Seed Catapult, Nectar Lure

WEAKNESSES: Drought





SEEDLING FLOWERING SEEDPODS

SWAMP MILKWEED

Wetland monarch host plant

#022



TYPE: WILDFLOWER

Swamp milkweed raises rosy flower clusters above narrow leaves in wet meadows and marsh edges. Monarch caterpillars feed on those leaves, butterflies sip the nectar, and ripe pods split to release silky, wind-borne seeds.

HOW TO SAY IT: SWAHMP MILK-weed

IMPERIAL MATURE HEIGHT: 2–5 ft

METRIC MATURE HEIGHT: 0.6–1.5 m

ABILITIES: Silkseed Drift, Monarch Host

WEAKNESSES: Drought



SEED SEEDLING FLOWERING

TURKEY-TAIL FUNGUS

Banded wood decomposer

#023

TYPE: FUNGUS

Turkey-tail stacks thin, leathery fans across dead deciduous wood, each cap banded in colors like a fanned feather. Tiny pores cover the pale underside, releasing spores as the fungus decomposes the log.

HOW TO SAY IT: TUR-kee-tayl FUN-gus

IMPERIAL CAP WIDTH: 1–4 in

METRIC CAP WIDTH: 2.5–10 cm

ABILITIES: Wood Breakdown, Pore Release

WEAKNESSES: Dead-wood dependence





MYCELIUM YOUNG MATURE

#024

VIRGINIA OPOSSUM

Nocturnal marsupial climber



TYPE: MAMMAL

After dark, Virginia opossums patrol forests, stream edges, and towns for fruit, insects, eggs, and carrion. A prehensile tail and opposable hind toes help them climb, while newborns complete early development in the mother's pouch.

HOW TO SAY IT: vehr-JIN-yuh oh-POS-um

IMPERIAL HEAD-AND-BODY LENGTH: 15–24 in

METRIC HEAD-AND-BODY LENGTH: 38–61 cm

ABILITIES: Grasping Tail, Opposable Toes

WEAKNESSES: Deep snow, Extreme cold



NEWBORN YOUNG ADULT

CLOSE LOOK KIT

Binoculars + hand lens + mirror

KIT 1



POWER Detail Zoom

BEST FOR Birds, butterflies, bark and fungus pores.

TOOLS Close-focusing 8x binoculars; 10x hand lens; Small inspection mirror

USE Find the subject with bare eyes, then raise the binoculars. Hold the hand lens near your eye; use the mirror below an attached fungus without picking it.

LIMIT Check the binocular's minimum focus distance. A hand lens needs a close, still subject. Never aim binoculars at the sun.

CATCH & RELEASE KIT

Soft net + viewing cup + card + brush

KIT 2



POWER Brief Close-up

BEST FOR Permitted observation of common small arthropods.

TOOLS Soft insect net; Ventilated clear viewing cup; Flat card; Soft brush

USE Guide gently with the card or brush; never pinch. Keep one animal in a ventilated cup in shade, observe briefly, then release immediately at the exact capture spot.

LIMIT The six featured sites are observation-only. Skip protected or unknown species, bees and delicate wings; never net birds, mammals, turtles or amphibians.

SOUND KIT

Phone recorder + optional directional mic

KIT 3



POWER Hidden Signal

BEST FOR Bird calls, toad trills and emergence-year cicadas.

TOOLS Phone audio recorder; Merlin Bird ID; Optional compatible directional microphone

USE Stop walking, keep fingers off the microphone and record quietly. Merlin suggests bird identities; use an ordinary recorder for toads and cicadas.

LIMIT Wind and overlapping calls can confuse identification. Confirm suggestions with sight or known calls; listen without playback. Observe closing times.

CAMERA KIT

Phone + macro lens + tripod

KIT 4



POWER Moment Capture

BEST FOR Close-up details, distant animals and home night visitors.

TOOLS Phone camera; Compatible macro lens; Small tripod; Optional infrared trail camera for permitted home use

USE Tap to focus and brace the phone; use a compatible macro lens for tiny subjects. For distant wildlife, use optical zoom if available and keep your distance.

LIMIT Macro focus is shallow; digital zoom loses detail. Put a trail camera only on permitted private property, without bait or disturbance; encounters vary.

RYERSON CONSERVATION AREA

Des Plaines River + flatwoods

R



ENTRANCE 21950 N. Riverwoods Rd., Riverwoods, IL 60015

LOOK FOR Kingfisher and downy woodpecker: habitat targets. Turkey-tail: check dead wood from the trail.

WHEN Daylight; spring through fall for the river-and-fungi combination. Woodpeckers can be sought year-round.

RECORD LCFPD recommends kingfishers and woodpeckers here at family level; these species are search suggestions.

ACCESS 6:30 a.m.-sunset. Observation only; no collecting.

MAP / INFO

HELLER NATURE CENTER

Prairie + oak-hickory woods + pond

H



ENTRANCE 2821 Ridge Rd., Highland Park, IL 60035

LOOK FOR Jack-in-the-pulpit: documented in the woods. Monarchs and common eastern bumble bees: sunny-flower habitat targets.

WHEN Spring for jack-in-the-pulpit; warm summer days for flower visitors.

RECORD The park district documents jack-in-the-pulpit; pollinator matches are habitat suggestions.

ACCESS Trails 7:30 a.m.-dusk. Observation only; leave plants and wildlife in place.

MAP / INFO

PRAIRIE WOLF

Wet prairie + 20-acre wetland + oak woods

P



ENTRANCE 11403 W. Route 22, Deerfield, IL 60015

LOOK FOR Common green darner, monarch and common eastern bumble bee: habitat targets.

WHEN Warm spring-to-fall daylight, especially summer flower season.

RECORD Habitat suggestions. Swamp milkweed appears in a restoration planting plan; present survival is unverified.

ACCESS 6:30 a.m.-sunset. Use Route 22 entrance; the dog area has separate access. Observation only.

MAP / INFO

MIDDLEFORK SAVANNA

Savanna + marsh + wet prairie

M



ENTRANCE 1401 Middlefork Dr., Lake Forest, IL 60045

LOOK FOR American toad, eastern tiger salamander and snapping turtle: historical site records.

WHEN Spring for amphibian breeding habitat; warmer months for turtles. Salamanders are elusive and mostly underground.

RECORD Recorded in a 1991-93 survey; these are historical records, not current sighting promises.

ACCESS 6:30 a.m.-sunset. Bear left at the end of Middlefork Drive. Observation only.

MAP / INFO

SOMME WOODS

Bur-oak woods + seasonal ponds

S



ENTRANCE Dundee Rd., east of S. Waukegan Ave., Northbrook, IL 60062

LOOK FOR Bur oak: documented woodland tree. Chipmunk and downy woodpecker: habitat targets.

WHEN Daylight year-round for bark; growing season for leaves and fall for acorns.

RECORD Cook County documents bur and white oak woodlands; animal matches are habitat suggestions.

ACCESS Sunrise-sunset. Stay within mapped public trails; no collecting or wildlife disturbance.

MAP / INFO

CAPTAIN DANIEL WRIGHT WOODS

Oak-maple woods + pond + river

W



ENTRANCE 24830 St. Mary's Rd., Mettawa, IL 60045

LOOK FOR Giant puffball and shagbark hickory: documented onsite in a 2023 naturalist report.

WHEN Daylight; fall for fresh puffballs and hickory nuts, any season for shaggy mature bark.

RECORD Site records establish occurrence, not a living specimen beside a specific trail.

ACCESS 6:30 a.m.-sunset. Main entrance at St. Mary's/Everett roads. Observation only; leave fungi in place.

MAP / INFO

CREATURE FINDER

PLACE CODES | SEASON | TIME | TOOL

24

CREATURE	WHERE	SEASON	TIME	BEST TOOL
American Toad	M [old]	Spring-summer	Day: tadpoles	Shore photos
Belted Kingfisher	R?	Ice-free water	Day	Binoculars
Big Dipper Firefly	HOME?	Summer	Dusk	Video; no flash
Bold Jumping Spider	HOME?; H?	Warm months	Day	Macro photo
Bur Oak	S [site]	All year	Day	Bark/leaf photo
Common Eastern Bumble Bee	H?; P?	Spring-fall	Day	Flower photos
Common Green Darner	P?	Spring-fall	Day	Binoculars
Common Snapping Turtle	M [old]	Spring-fall	Day	Distant photos
Downy Woodpecker	R?; S?	All year	Day	Binoculars/audio
Eastern Chipmunk	H?; S?	Spring-fall	Day	Binoculars
Eastern Tiger Salamander	M [old]	Spring-summer	Day: larvae	Shore photos
Giant Puffball	W [site]	Fall	Day	Photo
Jack-in-the-pulpit	H [site]	Spring flowers	Day	Photo/lens
Jack-o'-lantern mushroom	R?; W?	Summer-fall	Day	Photo; don't eat
Monarch butterfly	H?; P?	Summer-fall	Day	Photo/binoculars
Periodical cicada (Brood XIII)	Local woods?	Next main: 2041	Day	Audio/photo
Pillbug	HOME?	Thawed ground	Damp shade	Lens/cup*
Quaking aspen	Site unverified	Leaf season	Day	Leaf/bark photo
Shagbark hickory	W [site]	All year	Day	Bark photo
Southern flying squirrel	HOME?	All year	Night	IR camera*
Spotted touch-me-not	R?; W?	Summer-fall	Day	Flower photo
Swamp milkweed	P [plan]	Summer flowers	Day	Flower photo
Turkey-tail fungus	R?; W?	May-Dec.	Day	Lens + mirror
Virginia opossum	HOME?	Milder weather	Night	IR camera*

R Ryerson | H Heller | P Prairie Wolf | M Middlefork | S Somme | W Wright. [site] named-site documentation; [old] 1991-93 survey; [plan] planting plan only; ? suitable habitat, presence unverified.

Seasons are broad search windows, not guarantees. HOME? means permitted home habitat; * cup only where capture is allowed, IR camera only with property permission. All six featured sites: observe only; check posted closures and leave by closing. Brood XIII last emerged in 2024; next main emergence: 2041. Quaking aspen: sunny woodland-edge habitat; a local stand remains unverified.